

financial consultant who hand-held the couple through those dark days. "I wasn't fully convinced, but the fact that someone else was making me see things differently helped me," says Tilak. Financial stress could be short-term like a job loss or the way the pandemic impacted our finances. Then there are times when financial stress is chronic and deep-rooted. For instance, families which live paycheque-to-paycheque and struggle to make ends meet fall in this category.

Whatever your financial stress is, if it is left unaddressed, it can snowball into something bigger. Financial stress can impact your general as well as financial behaviour. Individuals who have faced extreme financial hardship while growing up tend to carry greater financial insecurities even when they are well-to-do in later years. Some splurge the minute they can afford to overcome all the hardships they faced in earlier years. Then there are life events which could cause financial trauma.

HANDLING TRAUMATIC EVENTS

Like any other 22-year-old, Jaspreet Narang was enjoying his new-found financial freedom with his first job when tragedy struck. His 54-year-old businessman father suffered a massive heart attack and died soon. The emotional trauma wasn't easy to handle and the financial troubles that followed was something he wasn't prepared for. "My father was running a successful garment export business with his brother for a long time. After my father's demise, I realised that they had liabilities which we weren't aware of," he reminisces. It took him months to come to terms with the real financial situation of the family.

Narang's mother couldn't believe it and his younger brother was too young to understand why from a carefree world, he was being made to budget. "My uncle was supportive, but there was only so much that he could do. I had to step in to not just revive the business as I was responsible for the many employees and partners we had," he recounts. His friends shared their wisdom of running a business and handling money, which he wasn't exposed to on a big scale.

Sometimes life plays out cruelly, something that Vidya R. faced after a bitterly fought divorce. "At 32, with a six-year-old daughter, I realised that my marriage was over," she reminisces. She had given up her software developer role to focus on family, while her husband continued to work in the same profession. The desire to earn more took him to offshore assignments which led to them drifting apart. "He started being erratic with financial support, which is when I figured that he was hiding something. My fears came true; in the name of an offshore assignment, he had actually married a colleague and left us."

Not to be cowed down, she took it upon herself to fight her divorce and extract a handsome financial settlement. "My advice: never take your financial life for granted and not to take long career breaks," she says. The two-year legal battle drained her emotionally and financially too, but not only has she managed to keep her daughter's custody, she has got a handsome alimony and child support till her daughter completes her graduation. Everyone may not be as gutsy as her, but the financial trauma she underwent with no financial backing one fine day was an eye-opener.

There are many events which could cause financial trauma—job loss, death of a close family member, financial loss when investing, inability to repay loans, divorce or a health condition which could be debilitating or even the inability to cope with a windfall. However, at such times, your best resource is your friends and family. They may not be able to bail you out, but be able to help you with practical real-world advice, especially if they've been in a similar situation before. Also, there are financial counsellors who can help you overcome this phase successfully.

FINANCIAL WORRY INDICATORS

- UNABLE TO PAY RENT OR MEET HOUSEHOLD EXPENSES
- UNABLE TO PAY CHILD'S FEE
- UNABLE TO PAY NORMAL MEDICAL BILLS
- UNABLE TO MAINTAIN STANDARD OF LIVING YOU ENJOY
- NOT HAVING ENOUGH MONEY TO RETIRE
- UNABLE TO REPAY LOAN EMIs IN TIME